



## Vaishnavi denied fairytale ending



Vaishnavi Adkar was denied a fairytale finish at the ITF Women's Bengaluru Open, a USD 100,000 event, losing in straight sets to third seed Hanne Vandewinkel in the final.

The 21-year-old (**left in pic**) wildcard, ranked 690 in the world, went down 6-0, 6-1 in 56 minutes to the Belgian World No. 124 at the S.M. Krishna Stadium.

Nevertheless, it was a career-defining week for the Indian, whose previous title had come at a USD 15,000 event in Ahmedabad in 2024. She beat compatriot Shruti Ahlawat before stunning Mai Hontama (World No. 220), Taylah Preston (World No. 148) and Lanlana Tatarudee (World No. 126) to reach the final.

The run earned the World University Games bronze medallist 65 ranking points, lifting her to 466 in the live WTA Rankings and making her India No. 2 behind Sahaja Yamalapalli (World No. 397).

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Former World No. 2 and ex-head coach of the Malaysian senior men's team, Misbun Sidek, has begun his first coaching assignment outside Malaysia by joining Hatsun Badminton Academy in Thiruthangal (Virudhunagar) to train young shuttlers.

The 65-year-old will visit the academy three times a year. Speaking to *Sportstar*, Sidek praised the Academy's facilities. "When I was offered the job by Hatsun's head coach, B. Rajnikanth, I was initially reluctant, as I had never coached outside Malaysia. But seeing the determination of the team at Hatsun, I decided to accept the role.

"I have produced three World No. 1 players — Lee Chong Wei (2006), Rashid Sidek (1997), and Roslin Hashim (2001). I am eager to produce the fourth. Moreover, the facilities at Hatsun are really good, and its young players have great potential."

Rajnikanth emphasised the value of Sidek's presence. "Having trained several world-class players, we feel his tactical and technical inputs will definitely help our players reach that level. He will be visiting our academy three times annually. His energy levels at this age during training sessions are really motivating."

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